January 23, 1959

We reached the edge of the forest today. The mountains are massive, their tops hidden by clouds. The snow is hard underfoot, and each step leaves a sharp echo in the quiet.

A small bird perched on a bare branch near the trail, tilting its head as if studying us. After a moment, it took off suddenly, flying toward the ridge and vanishing into the gray sky.

The group moved carefully. Most laughed and joked, but their eyes kept darting to the trees. Igor stiffened when the wind shifted. Georgiy glanced back repeatedly, as though someone or something might be following.

Branches snapped under hidden weight, and snow slid silently from the slopes above. The air felt heavy and still, and I felt the forest pressing around us, patient and watchful.

By evening, a fog rolled in from the mountains. Shapes of trees blurred, and the world seemed smaller, colder. We made camp, pitched the tent, and ate quickly. Outside, the wind whispered through the branches, and for a moment, it felt as though the forest was listening.

Lyudmila

January 25, 1959

Today was... good. Really good. The sun came out for a little while, breaking through the clouds, and the mountains looked almost warm. The snow sparkled, and for a moment, it felt like we were walking through a different world.

I couldn't stop smiling as we hiked. Igor led the way, and everyone seemed lighter, joking and teasing each other about who was the slowest. Georgiy made another one of his ridiculous jokes about being chased by Yeti, and we all laughed, even if it was a little nervous laughter.

I spotted a squirrel darting across a tree trunk, then a flock of birds that rose into the sky in perfect formation. It made me happy in a way I haven't felt in a long time — like the world could still surprise you, even in the coldest places.

We stopped near a frozen stream to rest. The water under the ice made soft, bubbling sounds. I ran my hand over the surface, feeling the chill. There's something calming about being out here, away from the city, the noise, and the routine.

I know the mountains are still dangerous, and the weather can change in minutes. But today, I don't want to think about that. I just want to remember how alive everything feels.

Lyudmila

January 26, 1959

The morning light caught the snow just right, making it glint like diamonds. I couldn't help smiling as we hiked, Georgiy kept joking about getting lost, and even Igor laughed. I love how alive the mountains feel today, how every breath of cold air makes me feel sharper, awake.

We stopped near a ridge to rest, and the view was incredible. Snow-covered peaks stretched as far as I could see. A group of small birds flew past, their wings catching the light, and for a moment it felt like the world was only this, cold, bright, and endless.

But I can't shake a small unease. Semyon has been quiet, more than usual. He helps carry the packs, but his eyes wander constantly, watching the trees and slopes. There's something about the way he pauses, looking at nothing, that makes me feel... unsure. I can't decide if it's just my imagination, or if there's something about him that doesn't fit with the rest of us.

Still, today is good. I laughed, I ran a little in the snow, and I felt the sun on my face. I just... hope nothing spoils it.

Lyudmila

January 28, 1959

Yuri left today. He said he was feeling ill and couldn't continue the hike. The others took it lightly, Igor joked that he'd be missing out on the best part, and everyone laughed. It's strange, though. Without him, the group feels a little emptier, quieter in a way I can't describe.

But there's something else bothering me. Semyon. I keep catching him watching us, not in a friendly way, just observing, like he's waiting for something to happen. The others don't notice; they're too busy teasing each other or taking photos. But I see it. The stillness in his face, the way his eyes follow us, the way he pauses for a beat too long before answering.

Maybe it's nothing. Maybe it's just me thinking too much. But every time I meet Semyon's eyes, I feel that same chill again, like the mountain air has turned sharp around me.

Lyudmila

January 31, 1959

The storm hasn't stopped. The wind screams across the slopes and shakes the tent all night. None of us are sleeping much anymore. The air feels thick, like it's holding its breath, waiting.

Something is wrong with Semyon. I'm sure of it now. He watches everyone, not in a curious way, but like he's studying us. When I wake up at night, I see him sitting near the entrance of the tent, staring out into the dark, not moving. No one else seems to notice, or maybe they just don't want to.

Earlier, I saw him cleaning his knife, slowly, methodically. There was no reason to, it's been days since we used it for anything. When he caught me looking, he smiled. It wasn't a friendly smile. It felt... knowing.

I don't feel safe anymore. Igor tries to keep spirits up, but there's a tension between everyone, an uneasiness that never lifts. Georgiy whispered something about bad luck, and I almost laughed, but it came out wrong.

I can't explain it, but I feel like something is closing in, not the storm, not the mountain, but him. The way he moves, the way he watches... it's like he's waiting for a moment.

If anything happens, if we don't come back, I want someone to know I felt it coming.

Lyudmila